

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 11)

Page 52 - Elizabethan Poetry Before Spenser

Q1. How is the spirit of Shakespeare's age described?

- A. An age in which 'men lived intensely, thought intensely, and wrote intensely'
- B. An age of darkness and silence
- C. An age solely focused on monastic life
- D. An age of complete scientific rationality

Answer: A

Q2. What event marks the opening of the 'golden age' of Elizabethan literature in 1579?

- A. The publication of Tottel's Miscellany
- B. The publication of Spenser's Shepheardes Calender
- C. The birth of Shakespeare
- D. The writing of Gorboduc

Answer: B

Q3. How is the poetry of the first half of the Queen's reign characterized before Spenser?

- A. It was the greatest era of poetry ever seen
- B. While there was poetic activity, little verse of any distinct value was produced
- C. It was exclusively written by the Queen herself
- D. It consisted only of translations

Answer: B

Q4. Where is the best poetry of this early period to be found?

- A. In John Gower's works
- B. In the contributions of Thomas Sackville to 'A Myrroure for Magistrates'
- C. In Shakespeare's early sonnets
- D. In the mystery plays

Answer: B

Q5. What was 'A Myrroure for Magistrates' designed to be?

- A. A scientific encyclopedia
- B. A continuation of Lydgate's Falles of Princes, including a series of 'tragical histories' of famous Englishmen

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C. A religious text translating the Bible

D. A comedic play about judges

Answer: B

Q6. Which specific poem by Sackville is noted as the finest single poem written in England between Chaucer and Spenser?

A. The Steele Glas

B. The Induction to A Myrroure for Magistrates

C. The Complaint of Buckingham

D. The Faery Queene

Answer: B

Q7. What is George Gascoigne's 'The Steele Glas' (1576) known for?

A. Being the first regular verse satire in the English language

B. Being the first sonnet ever written in English

C. Being the first English tragedy

D. Being a translation of Dante

Answer: A

Q8. Who is considered the greatest non-dramatic poet of the Shakespearean age?

A. Thomas Sackville

B. Edmund Spenser

C. George Gascoigne

D. Christopher Marlowe

Answer: B

Q9. Where did Spenser receive his university education?

A. Oxford

B. Cambridge

C. University of Paris

D. University of Padua

Answer: B

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Q10. With whose nephew, Sir Philip Sidney, did Spenser form an intimate friendship?

- A. The Earl of Leicester
- B. Lord Grey de Wilton
- C. Queen Elizabeth
- D. Sir Walter Raleigh

Answer: A

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Page 53 - Spenser and His Poetry

Q1. Where did Spenser pass the remainder of his life from 1580 onward, which he viewed as a miserable exile?

- A. France
- B. Ireland
- C. Scotland
- D. Italy

Answer: B

Q2. What tragic event happened to Spenser in October 1598?

- A. He was executed by the Queen
- B. Rebellion broke out, and his castle was fired and plundered by a mob
- C. He was lost at sea
- D. He contracted the plague in London

Answer: B

Q3. Where is Spenser's 'Shepheardes Calender' (1579) categorized stylistically?

- A. An epic tragedy
- B. A pastoral poem of the artificial kind
- C. A political satire
- D. A sequence of sonnets

Answer: B

Q4. How is the 'Shepheardes Calender' divided?

- A. Into 12 parts, one for each month of the year
- B. Into 10 books, one for each commandment
- C. Into 4 parts, one for each season
- D. It is not divided at all

Answer: A

Q5. What issues does Spenser discuss in the 'Shepheardes Calender' under the guise of pastoral imagery?

- A. His travels to Italy

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- B. Scientific discoveries of the Renaissance
- C. His love for Rosalind, moral questions, and religious issues from a Protestant standpoint
- D. The history of the Roman Empire

Answer: C

Q6. Who is the subject of Spenser's elegy 'Astrophel'?

- A. Queen Elizabeth
- B. Sir Philip Sidney
- C. Sir Walter Raleigh
- D. Geoffrey Chaucer

Answer: B

Q7. What are Spenser's 'Amoretti'?

- A. A series of 88 sonnets describing the progress of his love for Elizabeth Boyle
- B. A collection of political essays
- C. A play written for the court
- D. A translation of Italian fables

Answer: A

Q8. Which poem, inspired by his marriage, is considered by common consent the noblest wedding hymn in the language?

- A. Four Hymnes
- B. Astrophel
- C. Epithalamium
- D. Prothalamion

Answer: C

Q9. How many books did Spenser project to write for 'The Faery Queene'?

- A. Six
- B. Ten
- C. Twelve
- D. Twenty-four

Answer: C

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Q10. How many books of 'The Faery Queene' were actually published during Spenser's lifetime?

- A. All twelve
- B. Six
- C. Only one
- D. None

Answer: B

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Page 54 - The Faery Queene (Part 1)

Q1. To whom did Spenser explain the underlying scheme of The Faery Queene in a prefatory letter?

- A. Sir Philip Sidney
- B. Queen Elizabeth
- C. Sir Walter Raleigh
- D. Earl of Leicester

Answer: C

Q2. Who is the central figure in The Faery Queene, chosen because he was the hero of the greatest British legend-cycle of chivalry?

- A. The Red Cross Knight
- B. Sir Guyon
- C. Prince Arthur
- D. Sir Calidore

Answer: C

Q3. How is the appearance of Prince Arthur in each story utilized by Spenser?

- A. To kill the main character
- B. As a link between one part and another of the gigantic design
- C. To end the poem prematurely
- D. Merely as a background observer

Answer: B

Q4. Externally considered, what is The Faery Queene compounded of?

- A. Accurate historical facts of 16th century London
- B. The traditional materials of chivalry (giants, dragons, knights, damsels)
- C. Scientific descriptions of nature
- D. Purely religious sermons

Answer: B

Q5. Unlike his Italian master Ariosto who wrote only to amuse, what is Spenser's Faery Queene inspired by?

- A. A desire for political power

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- B. A high moral and religious aim; it is a didactic romance
- C. A hatred for Queen Elizabeth
- D. Purely financial gain

Answer: B

Q6. What do the twelve knights-errant represent in the ethical allegory of the poem?

- A. The twelve apostles
- B. The twelve months of the year
- C. Types of the twelve cardinal virtues of Aristotle's philosophy
- D. The twelve kings of England

Answer: C

Q7. What is Prince Arthur the incarnation of in the allegory?

- A. Divine Power
- B. Temperance
- C. Justice
- D. Human Weakness

Answer: A

Q8. In Book 1, what virtue does the Knight of the Red Cross represent?

- A. Temperance
- B. Chastity
- C. Holiness
- D. Justice

Answer: C

Q9. Which knight represents Temperance in Book 2?

- A. Britomartis
- B. Sir Guyon
- C. Sir Calidore
- D. Artegall

Answer: B

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Q10. Who represents Chastity in the third book of The Faery Queene?

- A. Lady Una
- B. Cambell
- C. Britomartis
- D. Rosalind

Answer: C

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Page 55 - The Faery Queene (Part 2)

Q1. Who represents Justice in the fifth book of The Faery Queene?

- A. Triamond
- B. Artegall
- C. Sir Calidore
- D. Red Cross Knight

Answer: B

Q2. Involved with the ethical allegory, what other kind of allegory enters into Spenser's plan?

- A. Astronomical allegory
- B. Historical allegory (concerned with political and religious problems of the age)
- C. Culinary allegory
- D. Linguistic allegory

Answer: B

Q3. In Book 1, as a general allegory, what does the rescue of Lady Una's parents by the Red Cross Knight represent?

- A. The rescue of English kings from French prisons
- B. The work of True Religion rescuing Humanity from the great dragon, Satan
- C. The discovery of America
- D. The translation of the Bible

Answer: B

Q4. Who does Spenser identify 'True Religion' with in his historical allegory?

- A. The Papacy
- B. English Protestantism
- C. Greek Orthodoxy
- D. Spanish Catholicism

Answer: B

Q5. Who are represented as the foes of True Religion in Spenser's historical allegory?

- A. The Papacy, Spain, and Mary of Scots

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- B. The Scottish Protestants
- C. The English Monarchy
- D. The Puritans

Answer: A

Q6. Why might some modern readers find the allegory of The Faery Queene detracts from the human interest?

- A. Because it is too short
- B. Because many of the immediate living issues of Spenser's day have only historic value now
- C. Because there are no human characters
- D. Because it is written entirely in Latin

Answer: B

Q7. What is an obvious defect of The Faery Queene mentioned in the text?

- A. It is written in prose
- B. It suffers from its extreme artificiality and languid storytelling
- C. It contains no moral lessons
- D. It completely lacks poetic rhythm

Answer: B

Q8. Despite its defects, what is a very striking merit of Spenser's work?

- A. It has perfect dramatic pacing
- B. It has wonderful sense of beauty, pictorial power, and pure essential poetry
- C. It is entirely realistic and historically accurate
- D. It is highly comedic and satirical

Answer: B

Q9. Because of the quality of pure essential poetry found in his work, what title has been given to Spenser?

- A. The father of English prose
- B. The poet's poet
- C. The king's playwright
- D. The morning star of the Renaissance

Answer: B

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Q10. Spenser's work represents a combination of the spirit of the Renaissance with the spirit of what?

- A. The French Revolution
- B. The Reformation
- C. The Enlightenment
- D. The Industrial Age

Answer: B

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Page 56 - Spenserian Stanza and Other Poets

Q1. Was the language used in The Faery Queene the actual English spoken in Spenser's day?

- A. Yes, it was identical
- B. No, he employed a dialect of his own which he purposely made archaic
- C. Yes, it was standard Elizabethan English
- D. No, it was pure Old English from before the Conquest

Answer: B

Q2. What is the name of the nine-line stanza invented by Spenser for his epic poem?

- A. Rhyme royal
- B. Spenserian stanza
- C. Heroic couplet
- D. Blank verse

Answer: B

Q3. What is the rhyme scheme of the Spenserian stanza?

- A. aabbccdde
- B. ababbcbcc
- C. ababdcdf
- D. aabaabaab

Answer: B

Q4. What is the last line of the Spenserian stanza called?

- A. An Alexandrine (a line of six iambic feet)
- B. A refrain
- C. A couplet
- D. A haiku

Answer: A

Q5. From what existing stanza did Spenser probably evolve the Spenserian stanza?

- A. Wyatt's sonnet form
- B. Chaucer's eight-line stave of The Monkes Tale

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- C. The ballad meter
- D. Gower's octosyllabic couplets

Answer: B

Q6. Following Tottel's Miscellany, many collections of similar character appeared. What is listed as the most famous of all of them?

- A. The Paradyse of Daynty Devises
- B. England's Helicon
- C. An Arbor of Amorous Devises
- D. A Handefull of Pleasant Delites

Answer: B

Q7. What did these collections (like England's Helicon) help preserve for us?

- A. Long epic poems
- B. Historical essays
- C. Many graceful pieces of verse by various authors
- D. Early prose novels

Answer: C

Q8. In what year was England's Helicon published?

- A. 1557
- B. 1576
- C. 1584
- D. 1600

Answer: D

Q9. What kind of books were also popular alongside these poetry collections?

- A. Cookbooks
- B. Regular song-books
- C. Chemistry manuals
- D. Dictionaries

Answer: B

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Q10. Besides being a great poet, what other trait made Spenser completely representative of his epoch?

- A. He was a successful playwright
- B. All the co-operating forces of Elizabethan England (Renaissance humanism and Protestant earnestness) entered into his work
- C. He became the King of Ireland
- D. He was a celebrated explorer

Answer: B